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» Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the fundamentals of the Indian economy and the rupee remain strong while ruling out any structural slowdown

» "In every Budget there is a clear sense that we respect taxpayers," she said, alluding to the measures of faceless assessment and the taxpayers' charter, introduced earlier

» The minister said that the income tax cut would also have an impact on savings and consumption in the economy with recent concerns over urban demand moderating. It will likely help sales of fast-moving consumer goods and also up discretionary spends by consumers

A BUDGET FOR BHARAT

(From left) **Sakshi Batra**, Senior Associate Editor, BTTV

Rahul Kanwal, News Director of India Today and Aaj Tak, and Executive Director, Business Today

Nirmala Sitharaman, Finance Minister

Siddharth Zarabi, Editor, Business Today

Sahil Joshi, Executive Editor, India Today

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THE UNION BUDGET 2025-26, the eighth one presented by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, unveiled a bonanza for the middle class by hiking the tax exemption limit to ₹12 lakhs and revised rates under the new income tax regime. At a time when the vagaries of external threats and a slowing urban consumption continue to plague the domestic economy, the tax cut is expected to put ₹1 lakh crore back into the hands of consumers.

Sitharaman, in her Budget speech, spoke about 'Sab ka Vikas', or development for all, and aimed to stimulate balanced long-term growth of all regions. Invoking Telugu poet Gurajada Appa Rao's verse 'Desamante Matti Kaadoi, Desamante Manushuloi', meaning, 'A country is not just its soil, a country is its people', the FM said the Budget focusses on the 'garib, youth, annadata and nari'.

The India Today-Business Today Budget Round Table discussed the government's aim to boost long-term growth. Here are some of the highlights from the event. **BT**